



STUDY GUIDE • IEUMUN 2026

INTERPOL

International Criminal Police Organization

Financial Sovereignty, Offshore Secrecy,
and INTERPOL's Fight against Illicit Global
Finance

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01

Welcome Letter from the Chairs

A LETTER FROM

Anastasiia Bolkhovitina

I am so excited to welcome you to this committee. Currently, I am a third-year student in IE, and I have been an “MUN kid” since I was 12 years old. My journey spanned from being a Secretary-General of the first international conference at my Ukrainian high-school to representing IE at Navarra and Harvard Model of United Nations (overall I did more than 30 simulations, crisis most recent years, so I appreciate the chaos being well-done). I also have participated in the European Youth Parliament, which I hope will come handy in this committee too, especially its deep emphasis on understanding the problem first.

The INTERPOL topic is especially meaningful to me, since I chose to pursue a degree in Economics and International Relations, out of a stubborn belief that diplomacy is mostly economics wearing a nicer suit. So please don't just arrive with pre-written speeches. Come ready to think on your feet, to adapt, to negotiate, and sometimes to change your mind when the room gives you a reason to. We are far less interested in surface-level debate than in seeing you wrestle with how genuinely complicated this issue is. And remember that we are here to help you do exactly that, so reach out any time you have a question or even just a doubt you want to talk through

Looking forward to meet you all,

Anastasiia

Diplomacy is mostly economics wearing a nicer suit.

ANASTASIIA BOLKHOVITINA

A LETTER FROM

João Vasconcelos Gonçalves

Hi delegates. My name is João Gonçalves. I'm 19 years old, originally from Brazil, and currently a second-year student of Business Administration and International Relations at IE University in Segovia! Model United Nations has been an important part of my life for a few years now, and I'm thrilled to continue this journey during my university years. I first got involved in MUN to improve my public speaking skills and to deepen my understanding of global affairs, but it has become much more than that, shaping who I am today.

Outside of academics, you'll probably find me doing activities outdoors or watching movies (always open to recommendations!). I sincerely hope this conference is a rewarding experience for all delegates, especially for those attending their very first MUN. Alongside the secretariat and the IEUMUN team, we're working hard to make sure our committee is engaging, inclusive, and impactful.

If you have any questions at all, feel free to reach out to me at jgoncalves.ieu2025@student.ie.edu

Looking forward to seeing you at IEUMUN,

João

02

List of Abbreviations

GDP	Gross Domestic Product
ICPC	International Criminal Police Commission (INTERPOL's predecessor, 1923–1956)
ICPO–INTERPOL	International Criminal Police Organization (commonly INTERPOL)
I-24/7	INTERPOL's secure global police communications system
IFCACC	INTERPOL Financial Crime and Anti-Corruption Centre
IFFs	Illicit Financial Flows
NCB	National Central Bureau
OECD	Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development
UNCTAD	United Nations Conference on Trade and Development
UNODC	United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime

03

About the Committee

The International Criminal Police Organization, known as INTERPOL, is the largest police cooperation body in the world, connecting the criminal police authorities of 196 member countries through a shared infrastructure of databases, secure communications, and international alerts.¹

It is also one of the most misunderstood institutions in international affairs, routinely imagined as a force of cross-border detectives able to hunt and arrest suspects anywhere on earth. The reality is narrower and, for the work of this committee, far more interesting. INTERPOL commands no officers, makes no arrests, and runs no investigations of its own. It is a network that allows sovereign states to cooperate, and its authority ends precisely where their consent does. Grasping that distinction is the precondition for any serious debate on financial sovereignty, offshore secrecy, and the policing of illicit money.

Mandate

INTERPOL rests on the legal foundation laid down in its 1956 Constitution, where Article 2 gives the Organization two aims: to ensure the widest possible mutual assistance between all criminal police authorities, within the limits of national law and in the spirit of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights, and to develop the institutions that help prevent and suppress ordinary law crimes.² Much of what the Organization can and cannot do is already contained in that wording. The clause “within the limits of the laws existing in the different countries” subordinates everything it does to national

¹ INTERPOL. What is INTERPOL? <https://www.interpol.int/en/Who-we-are/What-is-INTERPOL>

² INTERPOL. (2024). *Constitution of the ICPO-INTERPOL [I/CONS/GA/1956 (2023)]*, art. 2. https://www.interpol.int/content/download/590/file/01%20E%20Constitution_2024.pdf

sovereignty, while the reference to “ordinary law crimes” deliberately leaves out the political, a boundary reinforced by Article 3, which strictly forbids any intervention of a political, military, religious, or racial character.³ From these provisions flow the four principles that guide INTERPOL in practice: **national sovereignty, respect for human rights, neutrality, and constant and active cooperation.**⁴

In practice INTERPOL is a network, not a police force. It works through three layers:

- a General Assembly of all member states as its supreme body, an Executive Committee that oversees it between sessions, and a permanent General Secretariat in Lyon that runs daily operations;⁵
- a National Central Bureau in each member state, the single link between that country’s police and the network, communicating through the secure I-24/7 system;⁶
- central databases covering travel documents, fingerprints, DNA, facial images, stolen vehicles, and wanted persons, plus eight colour-coded notices, of which the Red Notice, a request to locate and provisionally detain a person pending extradition, is the best known.⁷

Most relevant for us, the **INTERPOL Financial Crime and Anti-Corruption Centre (IFCACC)**, created in 2022, coordinates the global police response to fraud, money laundering and asset recovery, and corruption, working alongside bodies such as the Financial Action Task Force and the Egmont Group of financial intelligence units.⁸

³ INTERPOL, *Constitution of the ICPO-INTERPOL*, art. 3.

⁴ INTERPOL. (n.d.-b). *Legal documents*. <https://www.interpol.int/en/Who-we-are/Legal-framework/Legal-documents>

⁵ INTERPOL, *Constitution of the ICPO-INTERPOL*, arts. 5–32.

⁶ INTERPOL. (n.d.-a). *Key dates*. <https://www.interpol.int/Who-we-are/Our-history/Key-dates>

⁷ Global Investigations Review. (2026). Interpol. In *The practitioner’s guide to global investigations* (10th ed.). <https://globalinvestigationsreview.com/guide/the-practitioners-guide-global-investigations/2026/article/interpol>

⁸ INTERPOL. (2022, January 25). *INTERPOL launches centre against financial crime and corruption*. <https://www.interpol.int/en/News-and-Events/News/2022/INTERPOL-launches-centre-against-financial-crime-and-corruption>; INTERPOL. (n.d.-d). *Our role in fighting financial crime*.

WHAT INTERPOL CANNOT DO

- it has no agents and no power of arrest, since every arrest is made by national police under national law;
- a Red Notice is not an international arrest warrant, but a request that each member may act on or decline, and many decline;⁹
- it does not investigate, prosecute, or determine guilt, all of which are matters for national and international courts;¹⁰
- it is not an organ of the United Nations, but an independent intergovernmental body;
- its Article 3 neutrality is contested in practice, as some states have misused notices to pursue dissidents and opponents under the cover of fraud or corruption charges, forcing INTERPOL to strengthen oversight through the Commission for the Control of INTERPOL's Files.¹¹

This is the paradox at the heart of our agenda: the same instruments that let states recover stolen assets can be turned into tools of transnational repression, and a committee on financial sovereignty has to keep both in view at once.

History

The idea of an international police body predates INTERPOL by nearly a decade.

In 1914, the first International Criminal Police Congress met in Monaco, where officials drafted early principles for cross-border cooperation and extradition¹², but the First World War suspended the project. It revived in Vienna, where on 7 September 1923 delegates from twenty countries founded the International Criminal Police Commission (ICPC) under Johannes Schober, president of the Vienna police, in answer to a new generation of

⁹ Global Investigations Review (2026), Interpol.

¹⁰ INTERPOL. (2024). *Repository of practice: Articles 2 and 3 of INTERPOL's Constitution* (3rd ed.), p. 4. <https://www.interpol.int/content/download/12626/file/Repository%20of%20practice%20Articles%202%20and%203.pdf>

¹¹ Parliamentary Assembly of the Council of Europe. (2017). *Abusive use of the Interpol system: The need for more stringent legal safeguards* (Resolution 2161). <https://assembly.coe.int/nw/xml/XRef/Xref-XML2HTML-en.asp?fileid=23524&lang=en>; INTERPOL (2024), *Repository of practice: Articles 2 and 3*.

¹² Deflem, M. (2002). *Policing world society: Historical foundations of international police cooperation*. Oxford University Press.

criminals who used cars, telephones, and open borders to outrun investigations that still halted at the frontier.¹³ Through the interwar years, the Commission built the foundations of the modern system: a 1927 resolution urged each member to designate a central national contact point, the forerunner of today's NCB, and by the 1930s the organization had created specialized units and launched an international radio network.¹⁴

The Second World War nearly destroyed it. After Germany annexed Austria in 1938, the Nazis seized control of the ICPC by deposing its president, and its leadership passed to a succession of senior SS officers; the headquarters were ultimately moved to Berlin, most member states withdrew, and the body was no longer functional.¹⁵ *This captured period is the reason the post-war organization treats political neutrality as foundational rather than decorative.* In 1946, police officials meeting in Brussels reconstituted the body as the International Criminal Police Organization, with a new headquarters in Paris, and brought "INTERPOL," long used as its telegraphic address, into common use.¹⁶ The modern Constitution followed in 1956, formally establishing the name ICPO-INTERPOL¹⁷ and the structure that governs the organization today, and the headquarters moved to Lyon in 1989.¹⁸

INTERPOL's membership and mandate have expanded steadily ever since. From twenty founding members in 1923, the organization grew to one hundred countries by 1967 and to its present 196 in 2023, making it second only to the United Nations in membership among international organizations.¹⁹ Its operational focus has widened as the character of crime kept changing, which brought us to this committee agenda of transnational financial crime.

¹³ Parliamentary Assembly of the Council of Europe. (2017). Abusive use of the Interpol system: The need for more stringent legal safeguards (Resolution 2161). <https://assembly.coe.int/nw/xml/XRef/Xref-XML2HTML-en.asp?fileid=23524&lang=en>

¹⁴ INTERPOL. (n.d.). Key dates. <https://www.interpol.int/en/Who-we-are/Our-history/Key-dates>

¹⁵ Deflem (2002), The logic of nazification; INTERPOL (n.d.-a), Key dates.

¹⁶ Deflem (2002), Policing world society; The Editors of Encyclopaedia Britannica. (2024). Police: International police organizations. Encyclopædia Britannica. <https://www.britannica.com/topic/police/International-police-organizations>

¹⁷ INTERPOL, Constitution of the ICPO-INTERPOL, art. 1.

¹⁸ The Editors of Encyclopaedia Britannica (2024), Police.

¹⁹ Wood, M. (2026). INTERPOL as an international organization. *AJIL Unbound*, 120, 11–16. <https://doi.org/10.1017/aju.2025.10044>

04

About the Topic

Key Terms

Illicit financial flows (IFFs). The agenda's headline concept. The first UN-wide definition, set jointly by UNCTAD and UNODC, describes them as financial flows that are illicit in origin, transfer, or use and that cross country borders, and they are a target of Sustainable Development Goal 16.4.²⁰

Money laundering. The process of disguising the criminal origin of money so it can be used freely. The UN's 1988 Vienna Convention defines it as converting or transferring property to conceal its illicit source, and it classically moves through three stages: placement (introducing the proceeds into the financial system), layering (moving them through transactions to break the trail), and integration (returning them to the owner as apparently legitimate wealth).²¹

Predicate offence. The underlying crime that generates the money in the first place, such as drug or arms trafficking, fraud, or corruption. Laundering is the secondary act of cleaning those proceeds.²²

Tax haven and secrecy jurisdiction. Related but distinct. A tax haven offers very low or zero taxation, often used to shift corporate profits; a secrecy jurisdiction offers legal and financial secrecy to people and entities based elsewhere, concealing who owns what. The Tax Justice Network treats secrecy as a spectrum on which every jurisdiction sits to some degree, rather than a fixed blacklist.²³

²⁰ United Nations Conference on Trade and Development & United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2020). *Conceptual framework for the statistical measurement of illicit financial flows*. United Nations. <https://unctad.org/publication/conceptual-framework-statistical-measurement-illicit-financial-flows>

²¹ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (n.d.). *Money laundering: Overview*. <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/money-laundering/overview.html>

²² Financial Action Task Force. (2023). *International standards on combating money laundering and the financing of terrorism and proliferation: The FATF recommendations*. FATF. <https://www.fatf-gafi.org/en/publications/Fatfrecommendations/Fatf-recommendations.html>

²³ Tax Justice Network. (n.d.-a). *Tax havens and secrecy jurisdictions*. <https://taxjustice.net/topics/tax-havens-and-secrecy-jurisdictions/>

Offshore financial centre. A jurisdiction that provides financial services to non-residents on a scale far larger than its own economy, typically pairing light regulation with strong confidentiality.

Shell company. A legal entity with no real operations or employees, used to hold assets or move funds while obscuring the people behind it; shells can be stacked in chains across jurisdictions.

- **Beneficial owner.** The real, flesh-and-blood person who ultimately owns or controls an entity, as opposed to the nominee or company named on paper. Concealing beneficial ownership is the core technique of offshore secrecy.²⁴
- **Asset recovery.** The process of identifying, freezing, confiscating, and returning the proceeds of crime and corruption to their rightful owners, addressed in Chapter V of the UN Convention against Corruption.²⁵
- **Financial sovereignty.** The authority of a state to govern its own monetary, fiscal, and financial affairs, including its laws on banking, taxation, corporate registration, and the movement of capital across its borders. It is the principle on which both legitimate financial privacy and harmful secrecy rest, and the friction it creates with cross-border enforcement is the central problem of this committee.

Introduction to the Topic

The defining dimension of this topic that we would want to explore in the committee is the tension between sovereignty and accountability. Under international law, each state decides for itself how to tax, how tightly to regulate its banks, and how much of a company's ownership to make public, and when a jurisdiction chooses minimal taxation and strong secrecy it is exercising that sovereign right. The difficulty is that financial secrecy is rarely consumed at home; it is sold to non-residents.²⁶ A secrecy law passed in one country becomes, in practice, an escape route for the citizens, companies, and criminals of every other country, letting them place wealth beyond the reach of the authorities that would otherwise tax or investigate it. One state's sovereignty thus becomes another state's enforcement gap, and there is no global authority that can simply close it.

The stakes are large and concrete. UNODC estimates that between two and five per cent of global GDP, somewhere between 800 billion and 2 trillion US dollars, is laundered every

²⁴ FATF (2023), *The FATF recommendations*.

²⁵ United Nations. (2004). *United Nations Convention against Corruption*, ch. V. <https://www.unodc.org/unodc/en/corruption/uncac.html>

²⁶ Tax Justice Network. (n.d.-b). *About the Financial Secrecy Index*. <https://fsi.taxjustice.net/about-the-index/>

year, and the same secrecy that hides a tax evader's fortune also conceals the proceeds of corruption, fraud, and the trafficking of drugs and arms.²⁷ Money stolen from public budgets is moved offshore and lost to the populations it was meant to serve, and criminal organizations rely on opaque companies and accounts to move and store their earnings. Because these flows cross borders while investigators remain confined within them, no single state can follow the money to its end. That structural mismatch, borderless money set against border-bound enforcement, is what makes international cooperation indispensable and also what makes it so difficult to achieve without touching the very sovereignty that members guard.

For delegates, then, the task is not to abolish financial privacy or to override national law, neither of which is realistic or desirable, but to find mechanisms that let states cooperate against the criminal abuse of the financial system while respecting their differing legal traditions and their legitimate interests in confidentiality. Holding that balance, between the accountability the international community demands and the sovereignty states will not surrender, is the work of this committee.

History of the Topic

The architecture of financial secrecy is older than the crimes it now conceals. Swiss bankers had cultivated client confidentiality since the eighteenth century, and Switzerland codified it in the Federal Act on Banks and Savings Banks of 1934, which made disclosing a client's identity a federal crime. Political instability, war, and rising taxes across early-twentieth-century Europe drove a flood of capital into Swiss accounts, and the combination of secrecy, a stable currency, and neutrality turned the country into the world's preeminent haven for hidden wealth.²⁸

After the Second World War, the model spread. As trade and capital globalized, a network of offshore financial centres grew up across the Caribbean, the European microstates, and a number of British and Crown dependencies, each offering some mix of low tax, light regulation, and confidentiality to non-residents.²⁹ The essential instrument was the shell company, an entity that exists only on paper and can be layered in chains across several jurisdictions until the real owner disappears from view, and by the late twentieth century an entire professional industry of lawyers, accountants, and corporate service providers had grown up to build and maintain these structures.

²⁷ UNODC (n.d.), *Money laundering: Overview*.

²⁸ Palan, R., Murphy, R., & Chavagneux, C. (2010). *Tax havens: How globalization really works*. Cornell University Press.

²⁹ Palan, Murphy & Chavagneux (2010), *Tax havens*.

International concern hardened as the link between secrecy and serious crime became undeniable. The UN's 1988 Vienna Convention criminalized the laundering of drug proceeds, the G7 created the Financial Action Task Force in 1989 to set anti-money-laundering standards, and in 2015 the international community wrote the reduction of illicit financial flows into the Sustainable Development Goals.³⁰ These milestones marked a shift from treating secrecy as a private matter to treating it as a shared problem of security and development, though the detailed record of what has since been done about it belongs to the sections that follow.

What turned the issue from a technical debate into a public reckoning was a series of journalistic leaks. Beginning with the International Consortium of Investigative Journalists' Offshore Leaks in 2013 and culminating in the Panama Papers of 2016 and the Pandora Papers of 2021, millions of leaked records laid bare the inner workings of the offshore world. The Panama Papers alone comprised some 11.5 million documents from a single law firm and exposed the secret holdings of twelve world leaders along with scores of other politicians and criminals;³¹ the Pandora Papers drew on nearly twelve million records from fourteen providers and named more than 330 politicians and 35 current or former heads of state across more than ninety countries.³² The leaks showed that the same machinery served tax-shy billionaires, corrupt officials, and organized crime alike, and that the most significant secrecy enablers were not only small islands but included some of the world's largest economies.³³

The exposure accelerated a retreat from absolute secrecy. Under pressure from the OECD and the G20, dozens of jurisdictions adopted the automatic exchange of financial account information, and Switzerland, the historic home of bank secrecy, began exchanging client data with foreign tax authorities in 2018.³⁴ Yet the system has proved adaptable rather than defeated: as some doors closed, business migrated toward jurisdictions that stayed opaque, including, by several measures, certain states within the United States itself.³⁵ The result is the landscape this committee inherits, one in which a formal norm of transparency now coexists with a resilient infrastructure of secrecy, and in which the gap between what states promise and what they enforce remains wide.

³⁰ FATF (2023), *The FATF recommendations*; UNODC (n.d.), *Money laundering: Overview*; UNCTAD & UNODC (2020), *Conceptual framework*.

³¹ International Consortium of Investigative Journalists. (2016). *The Panama Papers: Exposing the rogue offshore finance industry*. <https://www.icij.org/investigations/panama-papers/>

³² International Consortium of Investigative Journalists. (2021). *Pandora Papers*. <https://www.icij.org/investigations/pandora-papers/>

³³ Tax Justice Network (n.d.-b), *About the Financial Secrecy Index*.

³⁴ Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. (2014). *Standard for automatic exchange of financial account information in tax matters*. OECD Publishing. <https://www.oecd.org/tax/automatic-exchange/>

³⁵ Tax Justice Network (n.d.-b), *About the Financial Secrecy Index*.

05

Current Situation

Problem Statement

The current situation is marked by a vicious continuous cycle: the framework created to monitor and prevent illicit financial flows has increased greatly over the last 30 years, however, the volume of laundered money has also increased.³⁶ Based on UNODC estimates, 2-5% of global GDP (anywhere from \$800 billion to \$2 trillion) is laundered annually through the international financial system.³⁷ The fundamental problem is that as organisations continue to develop ways to combat crime and illicit funding mechanisms, the people using those funding mechanisms discover weaknesses in the funding mechanisms.³⁸

Outflows of illicit funds disproportionately affect the states with the weakest regulatory infrastructure. This indicates that the countries which are most damaged by illicit finance are also the ones least able to combat it.³⁹

Traditional methods of money laundering include using shell companies, exploiting relationships between correspondent banks and pushing money through real estate. All these methods remain prevalent.⁴⁰ However, there have been significant developments in financial technologies which have allowed for more sophisticated channels. This includes cryptocurrencies and decentralised finance platforms (DeFi), which operate outside the traditional banking system and its regulations. This indicates that states and organisations struggle to monitor the use of these new technologies and struggle

³⁶ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2011). *Estimating illicit financial flows resulting from drug trafficking and other transnational organized crimes*. UNODC.

³⁷ United Nations Office on Drugs and Crime. (2011). *Estimating illicit financial flows resulting from drug trafficking and other transnational organized crimes*. UNODC.

³⁸ Levi, M. (2020). Making sense of professional enablers' involvement in laundering organized crime proceeds. *Trends in Organized Crime*, 24(1), 96–110.

³⁹ Ndikumana, L., & Boyce, J. K. (2011). *Africa's odious debts: How foreign loans and capital flight bled a continent*. Zed Books.

⁴⁰ Palan, R., Murphy, R., & Chavagneux, C. (2010). *Tax havens: How globalization really works*. Cornell University Press.

to monitor the flow of all these illicit funds.⁴¹ The largest method of money laundering remains trade-based. This includes manipulating the price, quantity, or quality of goods during international trade transactions. It is also one of the most difficult to detect.⁴²

One of the main deficiencies of the money laundering regulations, is that it depends on political commitment of members rather than binding international laws. Look no further than the Financial Action Task Force.⁴³ It has a mutual evaluation process, which has often been criticised for applying the standards unevenly. Developing states are often placed on grey or blacklists when they have regulatory gaps, whereas countries in the West do not comparable consequences.⁴⁴

INTERPOL suffers from constraints on its ability to coordinate multi-jurisdictional financial investigations. It is constrained by the requirement for voluntary cooperation from national law enforcement agencies.⁴⁵ These national law enforcement agencies all operate under different legal frameworks, data protection regimes, and often have different political agendas.⁴⁶

Past Actions

The first phase towards establishing the Financial Action Task Force was by the G7 at the 1989 Paris Summit. They intended to create international standards to combat money laundering.⁴⁷ They created 40 recommendations with a basic framework which included⁴⁸:

- Criminalising money laundering
- Customer due diligence
- Obligations for financial institutions

⁴¹ Financial Action Task Force. (2021). *Updated guidance for a risk-based approach to virtual assets and virtual asset service providers*. <https://www.fatf-gafi.org/>

⁴² Zdanowicz, J. S. (2009). Trade-based money laundering and terrorist financing. *Review of Law and Economics*, 5(2), 855–878.

⁴³ Nance, M. T. (2018). The regime that FATF built: An introduction to the Financial Action Task Force. *Crime, Law and Social Change*, 69(2), 109–129.

⁴⁴ Cobham, A., Janský, P., & Meinzer, M. (2015). The Financial Secrecy Index: Shedding new light on the geography of secrecy. *Economic Geography*, 91(3), 281–303.

⁴⁵ Deflem, M. (2010). *The policing of terrorism: Organizational and global perspectives*. Routledge.

⁴⁶ Sheptycki, J. (2004). Organizational pathologies in police intelligence systems: Some contributions to the lexicon of intelligence-led policing. *European Journal of Criminology*, 1(3), 307–332.

⁴⁷ Financial Action Task Force. (1990). *The forty recommendations*. FATF/OECD.

⁴⁸ Gilmore, W. C. (2004). *Dirty money: The evolution of international measures to counter money laundering and the financing of terrorism* (3rd ed.). Council of Europe Publishing.

■ Requirements for suspicious transaction reporting

Then in 1988 the United Nations Convention against Illicit Traffic in Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances, also known as the Vienna Convention, established an international legal basis for criminalising the laundering of money coming from drug operations.⁴⁹ The 2000 Convention against Transnational Organized Crime, also known as the Palermo Convention, was used to broaden the list of offences to include almost all serious criminal activity.⁵⁰ The 2003 United Nations Convention against Corruption further extended the framework to the laundering of money from bribery and embezzlement of public officials.⁵¹

After 9/11, the framework expanded to include the financing of terrorism. 8 special recommendations were created (called the Eight Special Recommendations on Terrorist Financing). And the United Nations Security Council adopted Resolution 1373 which required all member states to criminalise terrorist financing and to freeze terrorist-related assets.⁵² ⁵³ This also strengthened the tension between surveillance of financials and the civil liberties potentially being encroached upon.⁵⁴

INTERPOL has increased its role into financial crime enforcement, for example, the creation of the Financial Crimes and Anti-Corruption Centre (IFCACC). They coordinate multi-jurisdictional investigations and provide analytical support to national law enforcement agencies.⁵⁵ There was also the creation of the Egmont Group of Financial Intelligence Units, who facilitate the exchange of financial intelligence between national agencies.⁵⁶

Possible Solutions

The solution with the broadest consensus is to strengthen transparency of beneficial ownership.⁵⁷ This would register across all jurisdictions. The part without consensus is

⁴⁹ United Nations. (1988). *United Nations Convention against Illicit Traffic in Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances*. <https://www.unodc.org/>

⁵⁰ United Nations. (2000). *United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime*. <https://www.unodc.org/>

⁵¹ United Nations. (2003). *United Nations Convention against Corruption*. <https://www.unodc.org/>

⁵² United Nations Security Council. (2001). *Resolution 1373 (S/RES/1373)*. [https://undocs.org/S/RES/1373\(2001\)](https://undocs.org/S/RES/1373(2001))

⁵³ Winer, J. M. (2008). Countering terrorist finance: A work, mostly in progress. *The ANNALS of the American Academy of Political and Social Science*, 618(1), 112–132.

⁵⁴ de Goede, M. (2012). *Speculative security: The politics of pursuing terrorist monies*. University of Minnesota Press.

⁵⁵ INTERPOL. (2023). *Financial crimes strategy*. <https://www.interpol.int/>

⁵⁶ Egmont Group. (2023). *Annual report 2022–2023*. <https://egmontgroup.org/>

⁵⁷ van der Does de Willebois, E., Halter, E. M., Harrison, R. A., Park, J. W., & Sharman, J. C. (2011). *The puppet masters: How the corrupt use legal structures to hide stolen assets and what to do about it*. World Bank.

whether these registers should be publicly accessible, such as in the United Kingdom. Or whether it should be restricted to a closed list of law enforcement authorities.⁵⁸

Another possible solution is regulating professional enablers. This would mean extending mandatory obligations, such as increased customer due diligence, suspicious activity reporting, and record-keeping requirements. These obligations would extend to lawyers, accountants, trust and company service providers, real estate agents and dealers in high-value goods.^{59 60} This would require overcoming professional lobbies which are often very powerful, and would require much negotiation between oversight for regulations and the privilege portion of a lawyers job.⁶¹

Investigating and researching challenges for regulating emerging financial technologies is a less straight-forward process.⁶² This extends to cryptocurrencies and DeFi platforms and increased compliance for the use and creation of blockchain technologies. Investigations could go beyond the current technologies and move to developing new monitoring and preventative technologies, such as monitoring real-time transaction tools.^{63 64}

Real-time financial intelligence sharing through INTERPOL would be an incredibly practical measure. It would require establishing secure, and standardised channels for fast exchange of financial intelligence. The main parties would be national law enforcement agencies. It could build on the Egmont group model, however, it would be advised to increase operational integration.⁶⁵ This could dramatically decrease the time and resources required to conduct investigations.⁶⁶ However, any mechanism like this would require robust safeguards, for example, against misuse, data protection standards, or independent oversight.⁶⁷

⁵⁸ Findley, M. G., Nielson, D. L., & Sharman, J. C. (2014). *Global shell games: Experiments in transnational relations, crime, and terrorism*. Cambridge University Press.

⁵⁹ Halliday, T., Levi, M., & Reuter, P. (2014). *Global surveillance of dirty money: Assessing assessments of regimes to control money-laundering and combat the financing of terrorism*. American Bar Foundation.

⁶⁰ Boles, J. R. (2015). The two faces of bribery: International corruption pathways meet conflicting legislative regimes. *Michigan Journal of International Law*, 35(4), 673–713.

⁶¹ European Commission. (2021). *A package of legislative proposals to strengthen the EU's anti-money laundering and countering the financing of terrorism rules*. <https://ec.europa.eu/>

⁶² Financial Action Task Force. (2021). *Updated guidance for a risk-based approach to virtual assets and virtual asset service providers*. <https://www.fatf-gafi.org/>

⁶³ Foley, S., Karlsen, J. R., & Putniņš, T. J. (2019). Sex, drugs, and bitcoin: How much illegal activity is financed through cryptocurrencies? *Review of Financial Studies*, 32(5), 1798–1853.

⁶⁴ Auer, R., Haslhofer, B., Kitzler, S., Mayer, C., & Zetzsche, D. (2023). The technology of decentralized finance (DeFi). *BIS Working Papers*, No. 1066. Bank for International Settlements.

⁶⁵ Egmont Group. (2023). *Annual report 2022–2023*. <https://egmontgroup.org/>

⁶⁶ Sheptycki, J. (2004). Organizational pathologies in police intelligence systems: Some contributions to the lexicon of intelligence-led policing. *European Journal of Criminology*, 1(3), 307–332.

⁶⁷ Deflem, M. (2010). *The policing of terrorism: Organizational and global perspectives*. Routledge.

06

Key Stakeholders & Blocs

Western Enforcement Powers (France, Germany, United Kingdom, United States, Canada, Australia)

These delegations represent the principal architects of the contemporary international anti-money laundering framework. As G7 members and founding drivers of the Financial Action Task Force, they have shaped the global regulatory architecture governing illicit finance for over three decades, from the 1989 FATF mandate through the post-2008 push for automatic exchange of financial information and the more recent beneficial ownership transparency agenda.⁶⁸ Their position in this committee will consistently favor expanding INTERPOL's operational capacity, strengthening cross-border information sharing obligations, and imposing stricter due diligence requirements on professional enablers such as lawyers, accountants, and trust administrators.^{69 70}

The United States occupies a particularly dominant role through FinCEN, the Foreign Corrupt Practices Act, and the extraterritorial reach of dollar-denominated correspondent banking.⁷¹ The 2021 Anti-Money Laundering Act and the Corporate Transparency Act represent the most significant domestic reform efforts in decades, though implementation remains contested.⁷² The United Kingdom has positioned itself as a transparency champion through its public beneficial ownership register while simultaneously facing criticism for London's role in concentrating post-Soviet oligarchic wealth in British real estate and

⁶⁸ Financial Action Task Force. (2023). *Revised FATF recommendations*. <https://www.fatf-gafi.org/>

⁶⁹ INTERPOL. (2023). *Financial crimes strategy*. <https://www.interpol.int/>

⁷⁰ Nance, M. T. (2018). The regime that FATF built: An introduction to the Financial Action Task Force. *Crime, Law and Social Change*, 69(2), 109–129.

⁷¹ Farrell, H., & Newman, A. L. (2019). Weaponized interdependence: How global economic networks shape state coercion. *International Security*, 44(1), 42–79.

⁷² Cassella, S. D. (2022). The Anti-Money Laundering Act of 2020: Congress addresses the deficiencies in U.S. AML law. *Journal of Money Laundering Control*, 25(3), 473–488.

corporate structures.⁷³ Delegates should note that European delegations tend to favor multilateral rule-based solutions, while the United States has historically preferred bilateral enforcement and unilateral extraterritorial action, a tension that will surface in debates over whether new INTERPOL mechanisms should be binding or recommendatory.⁷⁴

Offshore Financial Centers (Switzerland, Luxembourg, Panama, Bahamas, Monaco, Liechtenstein)

This bloc occupies the most structurally complex and politically sensitive position in the committee. These states share a common economic interest in preserving the conditions of legal confidentiality, low taxation, and flexible corporate law that attract foreign capital, but differ significantly in their degree of formal compliance with international norms.⁷⁵

Switzerland and Luxembourg represent the institutionally mature end of the spectrum. Both have undergone substantial reform since the 2008 financial crisis, adopting automatic exchange of information under the Common Reporting Standard and nominally complying with FATF recommendations.⁷⁶ Their delegates will argue that secrecy has been replaced by privacy, a legally calibrated protection for legitimate wealth rather than a shield for criminality.⁷⁷ This position is contested by studies of the Tax Justice Network that have consistently ranked Switzerland among the world's largest enablers of illicit financial flows even after its formal reforms, largely because of the gap between legal compliance and operational transparency. Panama occupies a uniquely exposed position following the 2016 Panama Papers, which revealed how the law firm Mossack Fonseca helped clients across 200 countries conceal assets through anonymous shell companies.⁷⁸ Caribbean offshore centers such as the Bahamas will argue that enforcement frameworks designed by and for large wealthy economies disproportionately punish small island economies with limited alternative development pathways.⁷⁹

⁷³ Bullough, O. (2022). *Butler to the world: How Britain became the servant of tycoons, tax dodgers, kleptocrats and criminals*. Profile Books.

⁷⁴ Zarate, J. C. (2013). *Treasury's war: The unleashing of a new era of financial warfare*. PublicAffairs.

⁷⁵ Palan, R., Murphy, R., & Chavagneux, C. (2010). *Tax havens: How globalization really works*. Cornell University Press.

⁷⁶ Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. (2017). *Standard for automatic exchange of financial information in tax matters: Implementation handbook* (2nd ed.). OECD Publishing.

⁷⁷ Emmenegger, P. (2017). Swiss banking secrecy and the problem of international cooperation in tax matters: A nut too hard to crack? *Regulation & Governance*, 11(1), 24–40.

⁷⁸ Obermayer, B., & Obermaier, F. (2016). *The Panama Papers: Breaking the story of how the rich and powerful hide their money*. Oneworld Publications.

⁷⁹ Vlcek, W. (2017). *Offshore finance and small states: Sovereignty, size, and money*. Palgrave Macmillan.

Emerging Economies (China, India, Brazil, South Africa)

The emerging economies bloc approaches this topic from a structurally ambivalent position. These states are among the most significant victims of illicit financial flows globally. The African Union estimates that Africa alone loses over \$50 billion annually to illicit outflows, while Global Financial Integrity has documented comparable losses across Latin America and South Asia.^{80 81} Yet these same states have historically been among the most vocal critics of the international enforcement architecture, arguing that FATF's listing and delisting processes reflect the geopolitical priorities of its predominantly Western membership rather than objective technical assessment of financial crime risk.⁸² ⁸³ Countries across the Global South have been grey or blacklisted for regulatory gaps while jurisdictions such as the United States, which did not implement the Common Reporting Standard, face no comparable scrutiny. This bloc will be broadly supportive of transparency in principle but insist that any new framework be accompanied by governance reform giving emerging economies a meaningful voice in standard-setting.⁸⁴ China will support INTERPOL's operational role selectively, where it aligns with domestic enforcement priorities, while opposing frameworks that could subject Chinese sovereign financial activity to external oversight.⁸⁵

Gulf States (UAE, Saudi Arabia, Qatar)

The Gulf delegations bring sovereign wealth management concerns, regional geopolitical calculations, and ongoing credibility questions to this committee. The UAE, and Dubai specifically, has become one of the world's most significant centers for illicit financial flows, functioning as a destination for Russian oligarchic capital following 2022 sanctions,

⁸⁰ United Nations Economic Commission for Africa & African Union. (2015). *Report of the High Level Panel on Illicit Financial Flows from Africa*. <https://www.uneca.org/>

⁸¹ Global Financial Integrity. (2021). *Trade-related illicit financial flows in 135 developing countries: 2009–2018*. <https://gfintegrity.org/>

⁸² Nance, M. T. (2018). The regime that FATF built: An introduction to the Financial Action Task Force. *Crime, Law and Social Change*, 69(2), 109–129.

⁸³ Soederberg, S. (2004). *The politics of the new international financial architecture: Reimposing neoliberal domination in the Global South*. Zed Books.

⁸⁴ Vestergaard, J., & Wade, R. H. (2012). The governance response to the great recession: The "success" of the G20. *Journal of Economic Policy Reform*, 15(2), 71–86.

⁸⁵ Liss, C., & Sharman, J. C. (2015). Global corporate crime-fighters: Private transnational responses to piracy and money laundering. *Review of International Political Economy*, 22(4), 693–718.

Iranian sanctions evasion, and South Asian hawala networks.⁸⁶ FATF placed the UAE on its grey list in 2022, citing deficiencies in oversight of real estate transactions, precious metals trading, and corporate service providers.⁸⁷ The UAE was removed from the grey list in 2024 following formal reform commitments, though independent analysts have questioned the depth of implementation.⁸⁸ Gulf delegations will support INTERPOL cooperation on terrorism financing where security interests align with Western partners, while drawing clear limits around provisions that would extend international oversight to sovereign capital flows or real estate markets.⁸⁹

Geopolitically Isolated States (Russia, Iran)

These two delegations occupy a categorically distinct position in this committee as the primary targets of the most extensive international financial sanctions regimes currently in operation.⁹⁰ For Russia, the freezing of approximately \$300 billion in sovereign assets following the 2022 invasion of Ukraine represents what Moscow frames as the weaponization of international financial infrastructure for geopolitical ends, a precedent it will argue undermines the legitimacy of the entire framework within which INTERPOL operates.⁹¹ Russia will push for language explicitly protecting states from politically motivated financial investigations.⁹² Iran, facing near-total exclusion from formal financial channels, has driven reliance on hawala, gold-based transfers, and cryptocurrency.⁹³ Both delegations will contest the neutrality of INTERPOL's mechanisms and will be essential voices in any debate over the boundaries of INTERPOL's mandate and the protection of sovereignty within international financial governance.

⁸⁶ Carnegie Endowment for International Peace. (2020). *Dubai's role in facilitating corruption and global illicit financial flows*. <https://carnegieendowment.org/>

⁸⁷ Financial Action Task Force. (2022). *Jurisdictions under increased monitoring: United Arab Emirates*. <https://www.fatf-gafi.org/>

⁸⁸ Chatham House. (2024). *Gulf states and financial regulation: Progress and persistent gaps*. The Royal Institute of International Affairs.

⁸⁹ Hertog, S. (2010). *Princes, brokers, and bureaucrats: Oil and the state in Saudi Arabia*. Cornell University Press.

⁹⁰ Hufbauer, G. C., Schott, J. J., Elliott, K. A., & Oegg, B. (2007). *Economic sanctions reconsidered* (3rd ed.). Peterson Institute for International Economics.

⁹¹ Connolly, R. (2018). *Russia's response to sanctions: How Western economic statecraft is reshaping political economy in Russia*. Cambridge University Press.

⁹² Drezner, D. W. (2022). *The uses and abuses of weaponized interdependence*. Brookings Institution Press.

⁹³ Maloney, S. (2015). *Iran's political economy since the revolution*. Cambridge University Press.

07

Questions a Resolution Must Answer

- 1 How should INTERPOL's mandate be clarified or expanded to address financial crime, and what institutional safeguards should govern any such expansion?
- 2 What standards should govern the international disclosure of beneficial ownership information, and what consequences should follow for non-compliant jurisdictions?
- 3 How should the tension between national financial sovereignty and international transparency obligations be resolved?
- 4 What mechanisms should govern information sharing between INTERPOL, national financial intelligence units, and multilateral institutions such as FATF?
- 5 How should the committee address the role of professional enablers in facilitating illicit financial flows?
- 6 What governance reforms are necessary to ensure that financial crime enforcement is not applied selectively along geopolitical lines?

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